CONTEMPORARY STRATEGIC ISSUES & MANAGERIAL CHOICES [CSIMC]

Term VI, AY 2026-27

Course Objectives- Content-Schedule of Sessions- Evaluation

CONTEMPORARY STRATEGIC ISSUES & MANAGERIAL CHOICES [CSIMC]

Faculty: Professor Ranjan Das

Professor of Strategic Management

- **Industry Experience:**
  - **20 Years in Industry [pre & post PhD in Strategic Management from IIM Ahmedabad]**
- **Faculty & Consulting Experience:**
  - **32 years [IIM Calcutta and other business schools in India and select overseas business schools]**
- **Experience as an Entrepreneur:**
  - **18 years [overlapping with teaching & consulting assignments during 2008 onwards]**

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CSIMC : FOCUS AREAS

- This course is positioned as a Term VI optional course coming under SM area and is meant to help students identify the **contemporary strategic issues and its implications for making managerial choices at firm level.**
- The course, comprising two parts viz Part A and Part B, will help the students become aware of the contemporary strategic issues facing large and medium sized companies of the world and assess impacts there of. A set of carefully selected 20+ contemporary strategic issues, which are currently considered by top 100 companies of the world as key challenges, will be discussed as a part of this course
- The students will be able to understand implications of contemporary and relevant strategic issues affecting business worldwide and also any specific industry of interest at a particular point of time, and identify strategic options available at the firm level to respond to such contemporary issues
- This course will enhance students' understanding of contemporary strategic issues facing many industries worldwide [including those resulting from impact of AI] through analysis and discussion of specially organized case studies.

CSIMC : FOCUS AREAS

- Part A and Part B of this course together will assist students in identifying capabilities that are needed by an organizations to identify, source and manage the contemporary strategic challenges on multiple fronts and develop road maps to implement the chosen strategic directions.
- The special emphasis on discussion on 20+ contemporary strategic issues that are and will most likely be affecting almost all industries worldwide during 2026-2030 and developing a list of possible strategic choices under each such contemporary strategic issue are added value of this course
- The principal purpose of this course is thus to sensitize students about the contemporary developments mentioned under Parts [A] and [B]. The course is expected to help them draw important lessons for making and implementing **high-stake decisions within their organizational and industry context**.

CSIMC: CONTENT TO BE DELIVERED IN TWO PARTS – A &B

- This course has been designed to be delivered in two parts viz
  - Part [A]: Top 15 contemporary strategic issues which are keeping CEOs of top 100 companies in the world busy by way of examining the shape of things to come during 2026-30 thereby compelling them to review their existing corporate strategy and also competitive strategies of each Line-Of-Business-LOBs [which are part of their respective business portfolio] and
  - Part [B] Deeper insights on some additional 6 specific contemporary strategic issues, which have become major developments over the last decade and already have significant impacts on many industries

- Focus of Part[A] will be to specify - **for each of the 15 contemporary issues-** the following:

  [i] What areas are At Risk?, [ii] What risks are rising? , [iii] Why does it matter?

  [iv] What existing conceptual strategic management frameworks will be under tests because of the emergence of the concerned challenge and [v] Understand how does a company respond to contemporary strategic issues as relevant for the period 2026-30 [for understanding item v, discussion on a short case, specially organized by the faculty covering broadly [i] to [iv] as relevant to each of the 15 contemporary strategic issues - will take place]. **SEE NEXT SLIDE FOR A FEW MORE DETAILS ON THE STEP BY STEP APPROACH**

CSIMC: CONTENT TO BEDELIVERED IN TWO PARTS – A &B

- Focus areas of these 15 contemporary strategic issues coming under PART A and which will be delivered during the first 10 sessions have been listed in the subsequent slides. For each strategic issue, following items will be discussed with recent cases and examples during Sessions 1 to 10:
    i. What is the challenge and why is it strategic during 2026–30?
    ii. What is “At risk”?
    iii. What is “Rising”?
    iv. Why does it matter during 2026–30?
    v. Which existing strategy concepts and frameworks are put “at risk”?
    vi. Imagining the emerging future 2026–30: four steps to be applied to imagine the possible future
    vii. What are, and will be, CEOs’ likely strategic responses during 2026–30?
    viii. India lens: how this challenge affects Indian companies
    ix. A case discussion covering relevant issues from i to viii
- Content of PART B – comprising second set of 10 sessions – are listed in the slides after PART A.

15 Contemporary Mega Challenges – under PART A - Facing CEOs of Top 100 Companies

Tier 1: Macro and Industry Challenges [2026-30]

1. Trade War Fragmentation
2. Middle East Energy & Logistics Shock
3. Recession Risks
4. Regulatory Fragmentation
5. Shrinking Workforce

Tier 2: Challenges while Evaluating Strategic options

6. AI Value Gap
7. Agentic AI Governance

Tier 2: Challenges while Evaluating Strategic options

8. Cyber as Strategic Risk
9. Geopolitical Strategy
10. M&A and Alliances

Tier 3: Organizational Challenges

11. Scarce Skills Talent War
12. Redesigning the Organization
13. New Work Models
14. DEI Reset
15. Innovation Theatre

Tier 1: Macro and Industry Challenges [2026-30]	
The Challenge	**Brief description of the challenge**
1. Trade War Fragmentation	The global trading system is splitting into overlapping, fast-changing tariff regimes that outpace the multi-year cycle of building plants, suppliers and markets.
2. Middle East Energy & Logistics Shock	A live war has closed the world's most important energy and shipping chokepoint for seven months and counting, and firms cannot wait for it to end before deciding how to operate.
3. Recession Risks	A downturn that may or may not arrive on schedule forces CEOs to choose, years in advance and without reliable warning, between cutting now and being caught overextended, or holding steady and being caught unprepared.
4. Regulatory Fragmentation	As the EU, the US, China and India write incompatible rules for the same technologies and markets, a single global operating model becomes a liability, and compliance itself turns into a strategic cost center
5. Shrinking Workforce	With the working-age population falling across most major economies, firms built on an assumption of abundant, affordable labor must redesign how work gets done years before the shortfall becomes visible on the factory floor.

Tier 2: Challenges while Evaluating Strategic options	
The Challenge	**Brief description of the challenge**
6. AI Value Gap	Billions committed to AI capability are outrunning any firm's ability to prove a return, leaving CEOs to decide how long to keep funding a technology whose payoff date keeps moving.
7. Agentic AI Governance	As AI systems move from answering questions to taking actions on their own, firms must build guardrails for failures that have no precedent, before the first major one happens inside their own operations.
8. Cyber as Strategic Risk	A single breach can now erase a year of earnings and years of customer trust overnight, forcing cybersecurity out of the server room and onto the board's strategic agenda.
9. Geopolitical Strategy	With sanctions, export controls and alliance politics now capable of closing a market overnight, a firm's geographic footprint has become a geopolitical bet, not just a commercial one.
10. M&A and Alliances	As technology and trade barriers reshuffle who can compete where, CEOs must decide whether to build, buy or partner their way into a future that will look very different from the industry they inherited.

Tier 3: Organizational Challenges	
The Challenge	**Brief description of the challenge**
11. Scarce Skills Talent War	The skills a firm needs for the next decade, particularly in AI, are scarcer than the capital to pay for them, turning talent acquisition into as much a strategic constraint as market access.
12. Redesigning the Organization	The hierarchical structures built for a pre-AI, pre-remote world are increasingly mismatched to how work actually gets done, forcing a redesign with no proven template to copy.
13. New Work Models	As remote work, gig labor and algorithmic management reshape who does the work and from where, firms must rebuild their operating models around a workforce that no longer shows up the same way twice.
14. DEI Reset	As political and legal pressure reverses a decade of DEI commitments in some markets while entrenching them in others, a single global people policy has become nearly impossible to sustain.
15. Innovation Theatre	With innovation labs and AI pilots proliferating faster than any of them reach the core P&L, CEOs must tell the difference between activity that looks like progress and investment that actually changes the business.

CSIMC: SCOPE OF PART B

- Part B of CSIMC will discuss a few other contemporary issues that have been already shaping the way business is conducted these days and how some of these existing issues are either opening new opportunities or are worrying major companies of the world.
- These issues, listed below, are will be covered under Part B [Sessions 11 to 20] for getting deeper exposure
    - Growing importance of platform-based strategies and business models
    - The phenomenon of converging industries
    - Emergence of sharing economy
    - Digital transformation [including how AI will change the way different companies and industries will work and implications]
    - Growing importance of considering ESG and risks while making strategic decisions
    - Attracting higher valuation for maximizing shareholder value.

Session-wise Plan

[Part A and B together]

PART A: 15 Contemporary Strategic Issues Facing Top-100 Global CEOs (2026–2030): Sessions 1 to 5 [Contemporary Strategic Issues: 1-8]

No	Contemporary Strategic Issues	Level of challenge	Topic
1	1 2	Tier 1[Macro and Industry Challenges]	1. Trade War Fragmentation 2. Middle East Energy & Logistics Shock
2	3 4	Tier 1[Macro and Industry Challenges]	3. Recession Risk 4. Regulatory Fragmentation
3.	5 6	Tier 1 [Macro and Industry Challenges] Tier 2 [Strategic Choices]	5. Shrinking Workforce 6. AI Value Gap
4	7	Tier 2[Strategic Choices]	7. Agentic AI Governance
5	8	Tier 2[Strategic Choices]	8. Cyber as Strategic Risk

PART A: 15 Contemporary Strategic Issues Facing Top-100 Global CEOs (2026–2030): Sessions 6 to 10 [Contemporary Strategic Issues: 9-15]

No	Contemporary Strategic Issues	Level of challenge	Topic
6	9	Tier 2[Strategic Choices]	9. Geopolitical Strategy
7	10	Tier 2[Strategic Choices]	10. M&A and Alliances
8	11 12	Tier 3 [Organizational Challenges]	11. Scarce Skills Talent 12. New Work Models
9	13	Tier 3 [Organizational Challenges]	13. Redesigning the Organization
10	14 15	Tier 3[Organizational Challenges]	14. DEI Reset 15. Innovation Theatre

PART B: Other Contemporary Strategic Issues: Sessions 11 to 15

No	Contemporary Strategic Issues	Level of challenge	Topic
11	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	16. Growing importance of platform-based strategies and business models
12	PART B:	Other Contemporary Strategic Issues	16. Do
13	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	17. The phenomenon of converging industries
14	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	18. Emergence of sharing economy
15	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	18. Do

PART B: Other Contemporary Strategic Issues: Sessions 16 to 20

No	Contemporary Strategic Issues	Level of challenge	Topic
16	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	19. Digital transformation [including how AI will change the way different companies and industries will work and implications]
17	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	19. Do
18	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	20. Growing importance of considering ESG and risks while making strategic decisions
19	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	21. Attracting higher valuation for maximizing shareholder value.
20	PART B:	Other contemporary strategic issues	21. Do

EVALUATION

1] Group of Students initiated research and presentation on 15 select contemporary strategic issues covered in this course [one presentation per group – total 15 groups starting from Session 3]: 10%

2] Engagement level based on in-class CPs and case-based Quizzes: 40% [based on CPs and 5 quizzes to take place with prior announcement – no use of laptops and smartphones during quizzes]

[NOTE: Several industry and company specific cases [total 16] will be specially organized by the faculty for this 26-27 Course using data available from public domain and taking support of Generative AI]

2] End Term Exam: 50% [in case some quizzes do not take place, weight of end term will go up] – closed book exam and no use of laptops and smartphones during the end term exam]